

A field guide to expressive design

Visual styles, logo craft and brand systems

Living study edition 1.0 / 8 September 2026

How to use this field guide

- 01** Browse the visual atlas to learn the vocabulary.
- 02** Read the case studies to see how decisions work together.
- 03** Use the exercises and templates for future design reviews.

Four kinds of evidence

- 01** **Observed:** visible in an inspected image or page.
- 02** Documented: a source describes the process or rationale.
- 03** Interpretation: our explanation or design hypothesis.
- 04** Tested: a named check with recorded conditions and results.

Five questions for looking closely

- 01** **What attracts attention first? What appears related?**
- 02** Which cues create the apparent material?
- 03** Which parts carry information, and which create atmosphere?
- 04** What survives when decorative effects disappear?

The visual atlas

Ten labels. Several kinds of design knowledge.

The names describe different things

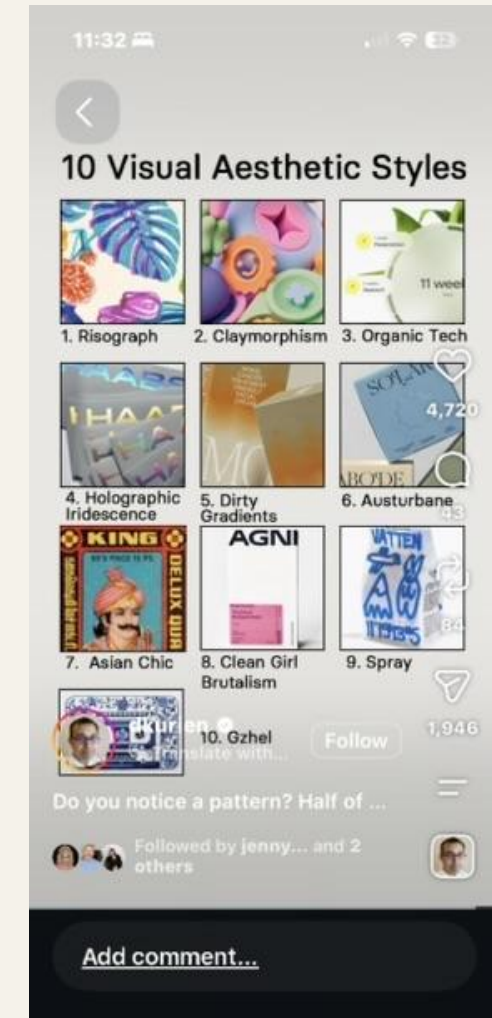
Risograph names a printing technology.

Gzhel names a regional ceramic tradition.

Austurbane is an attributed contemporary classification.

Other labels describe visual impressions or informal hybrids.

[Related research: tiktok.com](https://www.tiktok.com)



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Risograph

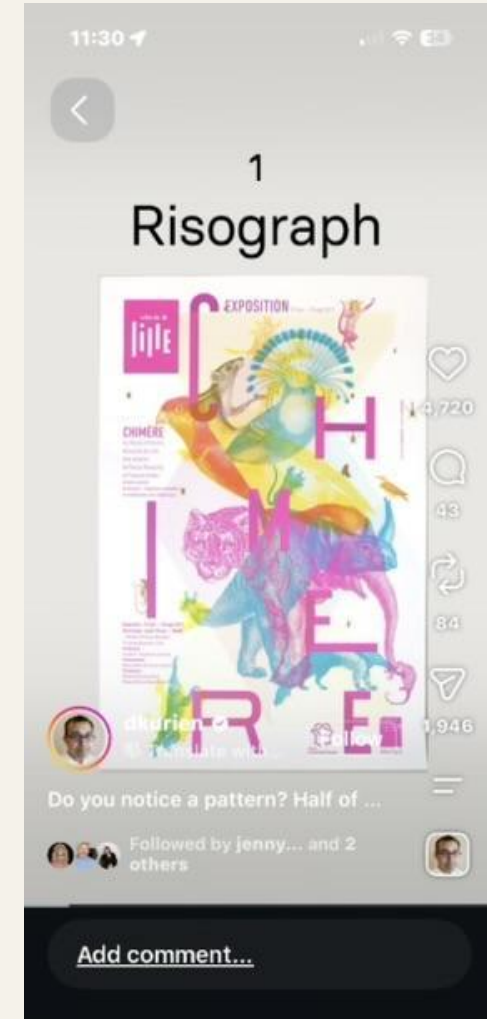
Separated spot colors create a layered composition.

Transparent overlaps introduce additional color relationships.

Texture can coexist with precise information.

Related research: pagemasters.co

Related source: risottostudio.com



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Claymorphism

Rounded edges and coordinated light suggest touch.

The reference combines fins, folds and glossy volumes.

A consistent material can connect different ideas.



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Related research: behance.net

Related source: microsoft.design

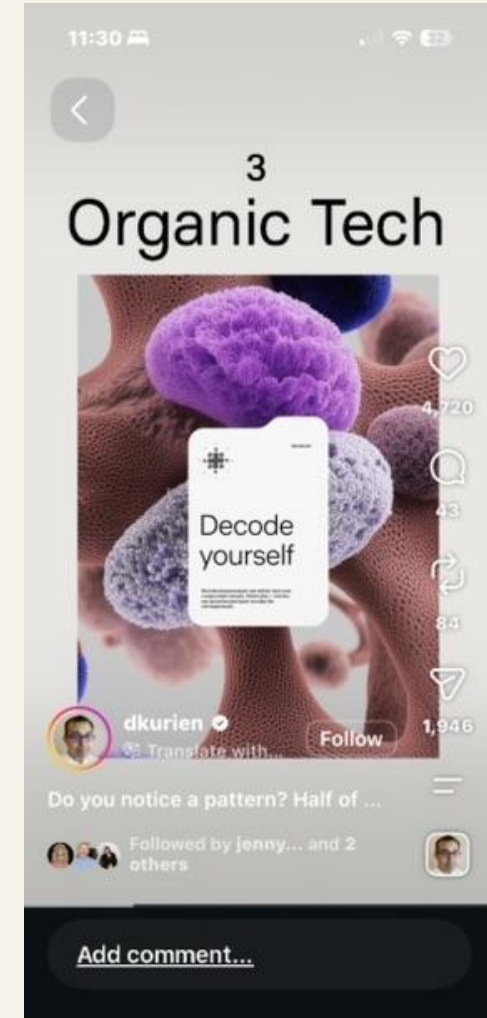
Organic Tech

Porous, tufted forms surround a plain information card.

Biological complexity contrasts with precise typography.

The subject should connect to a real idea.

Related research: agencecartier.com



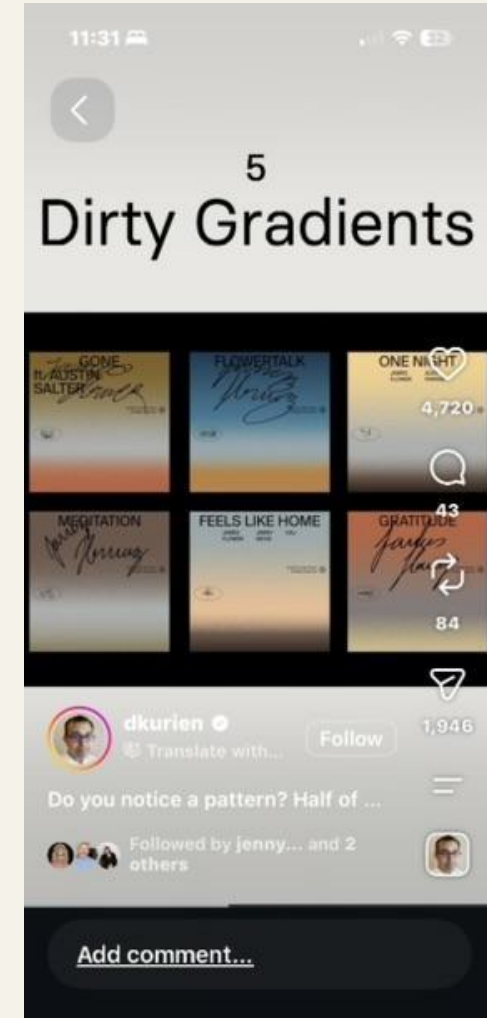
Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Dirty Gradients

Broad color transitions create atmosphere.

Muted mixing and irregular texture change the surface.

A quiet region helps the words retain priority.



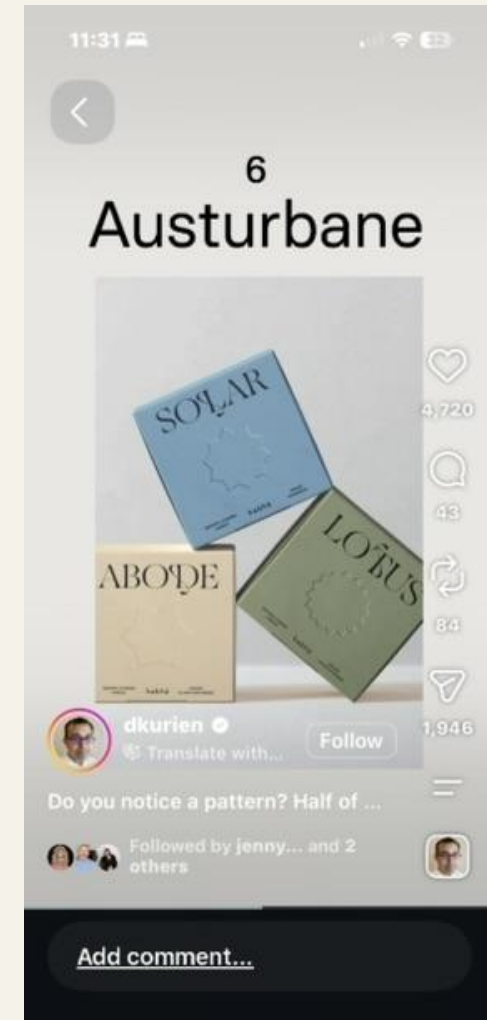
Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Austurbane

Restrained color and fine serif titles set a quiet rhythm.

Overlapping objects create depth and directional tension.

Lighting and materials contribute as much as palette.



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

[Related research: cari.institute](https://cari.institute)

Clean Girl Brutalism

A heavy title anchors the upper edge.

A large quiet field separates it from compact information.

One saturated pink block carries strong visual weight.



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

[Related research: cari.institute](https://cari.institute)

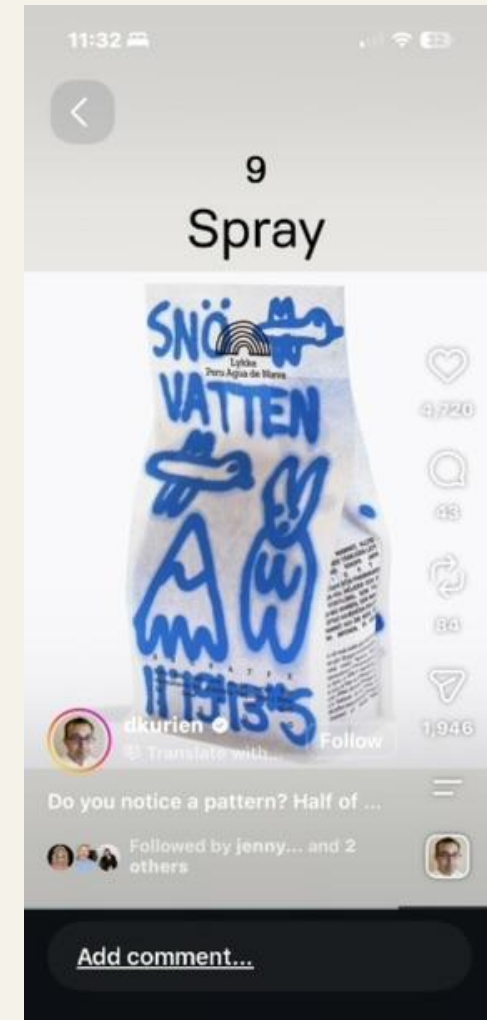
[Related source: riba.org](https://riba.org)

Spray

Blue gestural marks carry personality.

Small black typesetting carries product facts.

The arrangement stays organized while the marks vary.



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Related research: pentagram.com

Gzhel and the attribution question

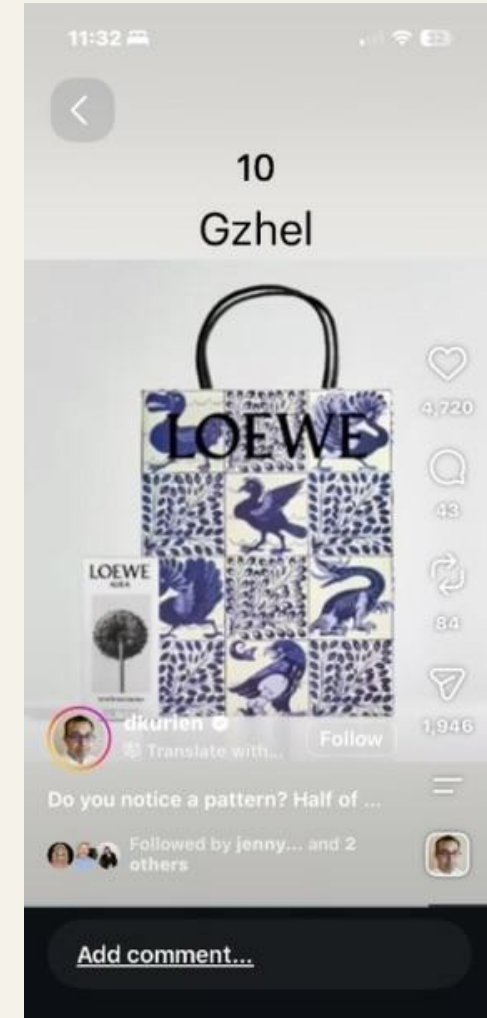
Cobalt-on-white can carry rhythm through tone and scale.

Repeated motifs and open space shape a pattern.

The LOEWE bag's Gzhel attribution remains unverified.

[Related research: unesco.ru](https://unesco.ru)

[Related source: farfor-gzhel.com](https://farfor-gzhel.com)



Visual: supplied reference screenshot

Holographic iridescence

- 01** Changing highlights suggest a responsive material.
- 02** Reflection, geometry and lighting work together.
- 03** A static rainbow fill cannot establish holography.

Cultural references need specific context

- 01** The source's "Asian Chic" thumbnail shows a dense frame and saturated contrast.
- 02** A maker, place and date are more useful than a broad label.
- 03** Lettering and motifs carry meanings beyond appearance.

Combining styles by assigning roles

- 01** **Typography and spacing organize the information.**
- 02** One material family gives imagery a shared character.
- 03** Color creates atmosphere or carries a defined meaning.
- 04** A gesture supplies emphasis where it is useful.

Logo craft and brand systems

How specific decisions become a recognizable family.

Nike: a silhouette with a job



1971



1976



1989



1992

Carolyn Davidson designed the shoe-side mark in 1971; its curve suggested motion.

Study the taper, direction and negative space rather than just its simplicity.

Its present familiarity is not a fair first-impression test for a new logo.

FedEx: meaning between the letters

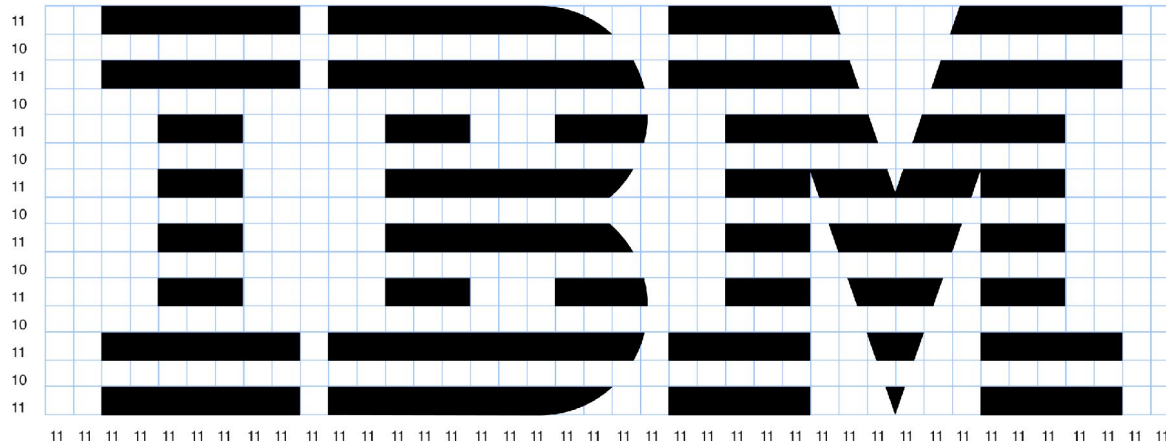
- 01** Lindon Leader describes reconstructing letterforms to create the E–x arrow.
- 02** The wordmark communicates the name; the arrow supplies a second discovery.
- 03** A hidden idea should reward attention without requiring explanation.

IBM: the mark lives inside a system

Paul Rand's 8-bar design dates to 1972.

Official light and dark versions use optical adjustments rather than a simple inversion.

Clear space, placement and consistent application protect the identity.



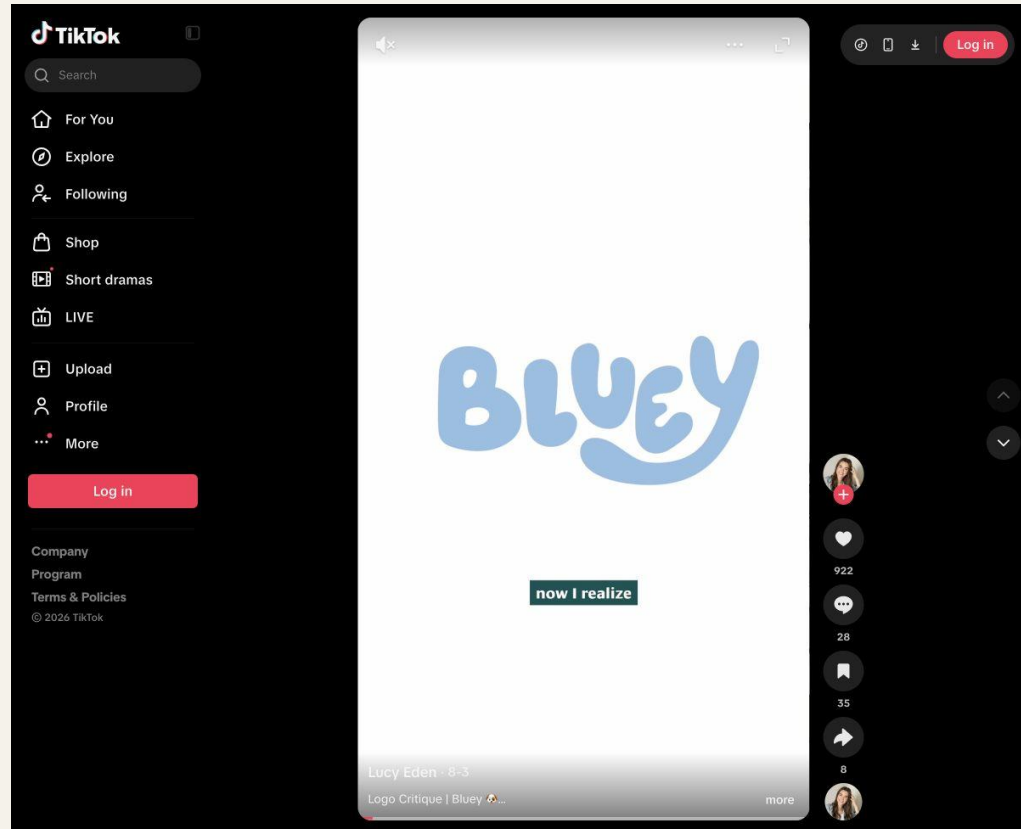
Recognition and familiarity

- 01** **Separate shape discrimination, prior familiarity and correct brand naming.**
- 02** Famous marks carry years of exposure and associations into the comparison.
- 03** For new work, test readability and learning rather than a claim of instant iconic status.

Logo critique: inspect relationships

- 01 Silhouette: what reads before the details?**
- 02** Interior spaces, curves and spacing shape the word.
- 03** Compare the full name and a compact mark.
- 04** Separate craft observations from personal taste.

Lucy Eden: refine the existing letter



Earlier sampled frames show Y-curve refinements.

A comparison outline makes contour changes visible.

Small changes can retain a mark's character.

Image: logo context; the editing frame is discussed in notes.

Michelle Elman: compose one unified name

- 01** Custom signature lettering nests into a unified arrangement.
- 02** A small speech bubble adds contextual character.
- 03** Patterns and illustrations carry additional expression.
- 04** Judge the composition against the intended personality.

Splatter: let the experience shape the letters

- 01** Paint-throwing experience informs bold, playful letter behavior.
- 02** Custom wordmark uses slanted and stacked forms.
- 03** A condensed badge adapts the identity to another space.
- 04** Real painted splashes become original supporting graphics.

Marlowe & Sage: repeat a distinctive relationship

- 01** Rounded serif lettering supports the intended warmth.
- 02** An intertwined ampersand connects the full name.
- 03** The compact mark reuses initials and that connection.
- 04** A type category alone cannot determine personality.

TBWA / DXD: making becomes a system

- 01** TBWA documents drawing, painting, cutting and experimentation.
- 02** The process supplies varied visual material.
- 03** A system still needs recognizable forms and clear hierarchy.
- 04** Maker process is documented; audience effects are not.

Anthropic: warmth and technical structure together



Geist connects the identity to human values and technical craft.

Typographic mark, Styrene/Tiempos and warm color work together.

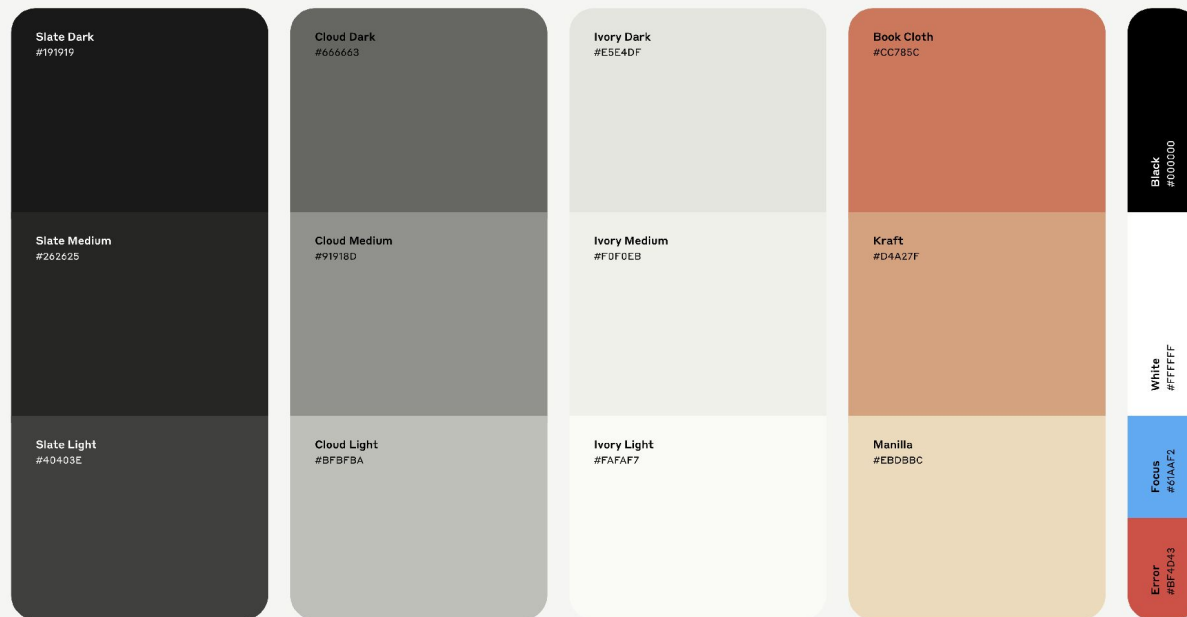
Illustration extends the language for varied audiences.

A UI component system carries the identity into use.

Naive design: useful hypothesis, limited proof

- 01** **Signals proposes hand-drawn character as a response to polished sameness.**
- 02** Irregular appearance cannot prove human authorship.
- 03** McLuhan references and 'exponential trust' are not measurements.
- 04** Keep expressive material; test clarity and real applications.

Anthropic's foundations



Warm color supports both communication and interface use.

Styrene and Tiempos bring different typographic voices.

The full system includes more than the logo.

Typography as a brand voice

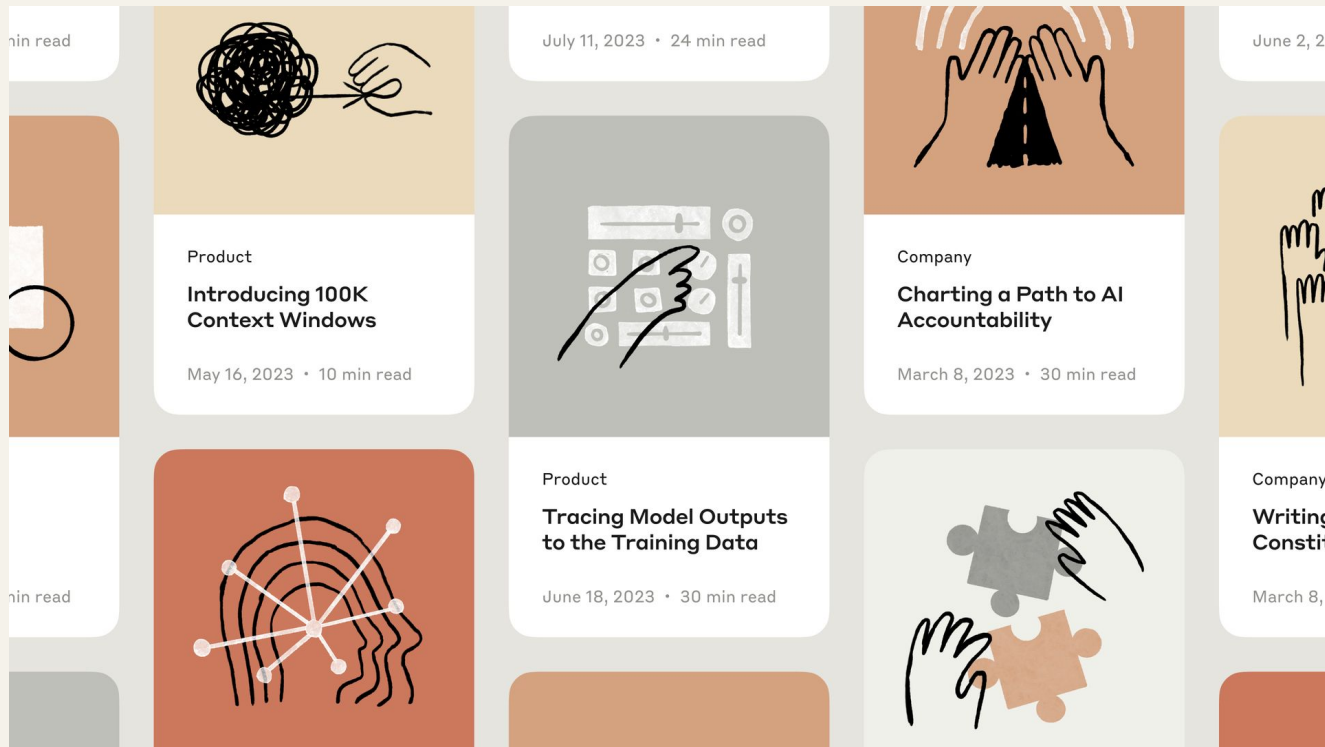


Letterforms contribute tone even without decorative imagery.

A pairing needs clear roles for headings and reading text.

Actual size, spacing and context determine the result.

A system across repeated content



Repeated content needs a stable information hierarchy.

Illustration can vary within that stable structure.

Guidelines make future choices easier to coordinate.

Design in use

Reading, motion and smaller screens change the brief.

Space tells us what belongs together

Even spacing

Material study

Light and texture

Color study

Hue and contrast

Related items closer

Material study

Light and texture

Color study

Hue and contrast

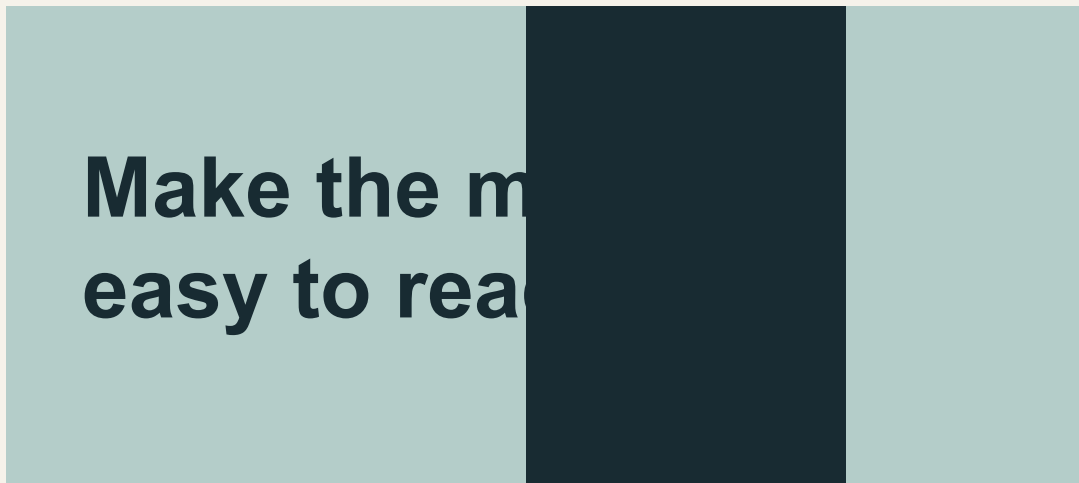
Same words, type and width. Only the description's vertical position changes.

[Source: palmerlab.berkeley.edu](http://palmerlab.berkeley.edu)

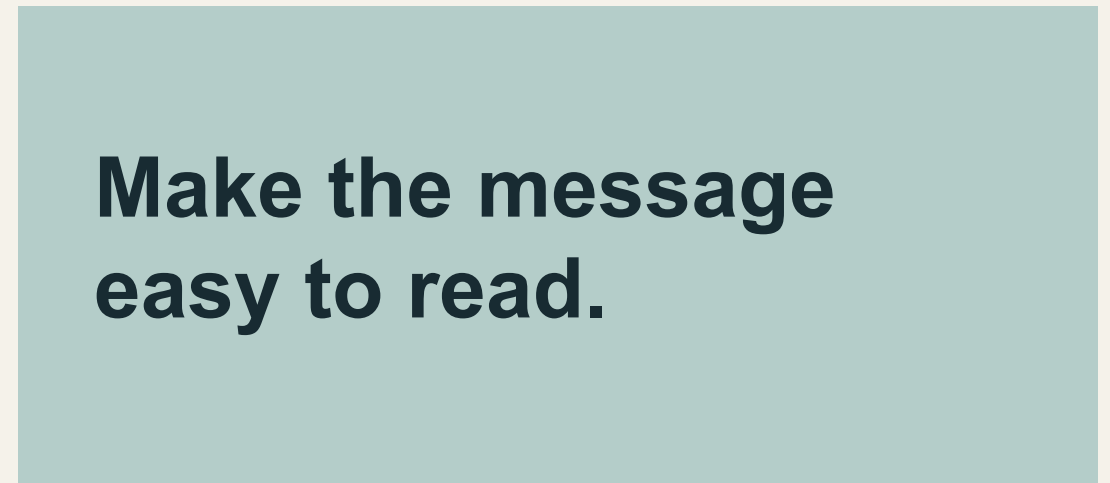
[Related source: cooperhewitt.org](http://cooperhewitt.org)

Protect the reading surface

Variable reading surface



Solid reading surface



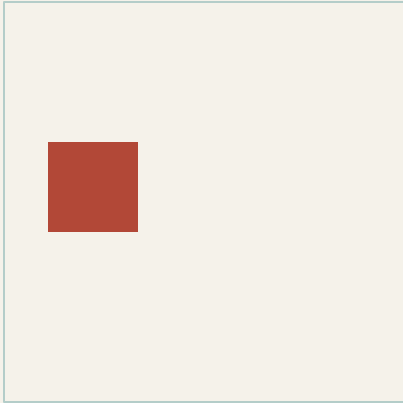
Check the background beneath each letter. A palette alone is insufficient.

AA minimums: 4.5:1 ordinary text; 3:1 qualifying large text. Exceptions apply.

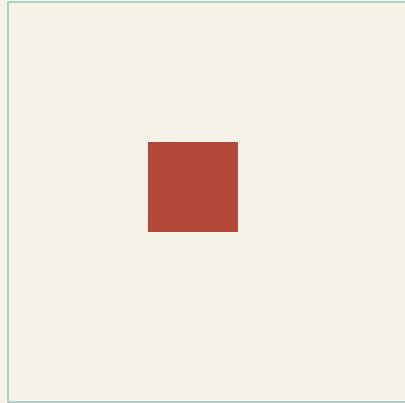
[Source: w3.org](https://www.w3.org)

Motion and its still alternative

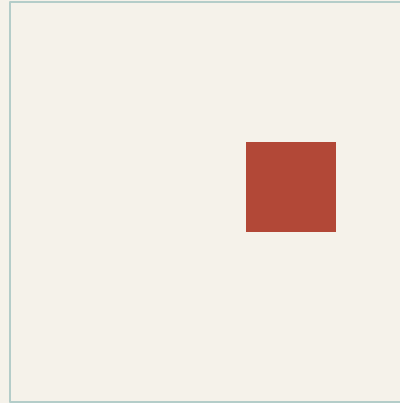
Proposed motion sequence



Frame 1

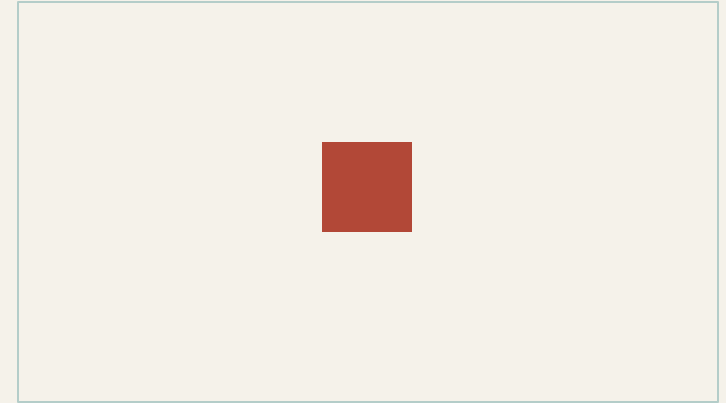


Frame 2



Frame 3

Still alternative



Meaning remains available

Keep meaning in the still state. Provide controls and reduced-motion support.

[Source: w3.org](https://www.w3.org/)

[Related source: w3.org](https://www.w3.org/)

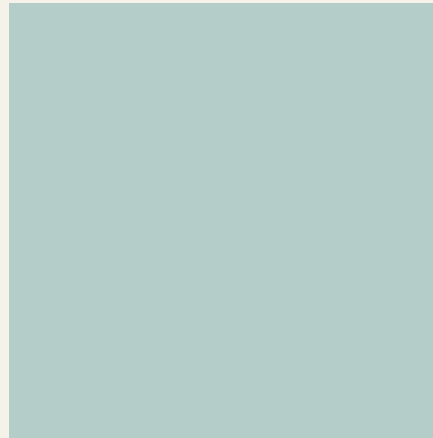
Translate the composition to a smaller surface

Wide composition

A material point of view

Light, texture and color.

Explore



Narrow composition

A material point of view

Light, texture and color.



Explore

Preserve hierarchy. Recompose the same text, image and action.

Choose the material effect and its cost together

- 01 Light, shape and texture jointly create material cues.
- 02 Compare a static authored asset with a live effect before adding complexity.
- 03 Measure bytes and rendering behavior; appearance cannot prove speed.

Turn a reaction into a useful design test

- 01** **Describe the visible cause before assigning a style adjective.**
- 02** Change one variable; keep the content and comparison conditions fixed.
- 03** Separate preference, documented requirements and measured results.
- 04** Record the next revision and what remains unknown.

Implementation choices in Squarespace

- 01 Native settings: verify the current documented editor path.**
- 02 Authored assets: retain originals and inspect exported crops.
- 03 Custom code or external services: record dependencies and rollback.
- 04 Test the result on the actual private site.

A repeatable design workshop

Shared language makes the next decision easier.

Exercise: material, spacing and grain

- 01** Compare bundled material treatments while holding shapes still.
- 02** Change title-to-description spacing and observe grouping.
- 03** Vary grain strength over fixed text and a fixed gradient.

New reference template

- 01** **Reference title, creator, date and source URL**
- 02** Screenshot and the specific detail to inspect
- 03** Observed mechanism and possible use
- 04** Unknowns, evidence status and next question

Design decision template

- 01** Requirement and intended audience
- 02** Alternatives compared under the same conditions
- 03** Choice, rationale and remaining uncertainty
- 04** Test evidence, owner, date and rollback route

Questions to carry into Levarum

- 01** Which feeling supports what the service actually does?
- 02** Which visual detail could become recognizably ours?
- 03** Where should expression appear, and where should reading lead?
- 04** What remains convincing without motion or decoration?

Keeping this library alive

- 01** **Keep this Google Slides deck as the working master.**
- 02** Add source dates and evidence status when a lesson changes.
- 03** Use named versions for substantial revisions.
- 04** Maintain a short change log and a list of open questions.

Research contributors and training

- 01** Three agents studied history, materials and perception.
- 02** Their sources and inspection limits are the verifiable record.
- 03** Role assignments do not imply separate specialist training.
- 04** Saving a library provides reusable context.

Edition history and open questions

- 01** **1.0 / 8 September 2026: first consolidated teaching deck.**
- 02** Source artwork attribution remains incomplete for several reel images.
- 03** Lucy's Bluey critique was sampled, not fully transcribed.
- 04** Audience response and Levarum implementation remain untested.

Source directory 1

<https://www.tiktok.com/@denny.kurien/video/7680157545746418964>

<https://www.pagemasters.co/risograph>

<https://risottostudio.com/pages/advanced-print-setup>

https://www.riso.co.jp/english/product/digital_dup/history/index.html

<https://www.behance.net/gallery/127686975/Simplicity-21>

<https://microsoft.design/articles/an-emoji-for-your-thoughts-2/>

<https://agencecartier.com/en/projects/farinart-a-new-identity-crops-up/>

Source directory 2

<https://www.pentagram.com/work/intrinsic>

<https://cari.institute/aesthetics/austurbane>

<https://cari.institute/aesthetics/nu-brutalism>

<https://www.riba.org/explore/riba-collections/architectural-styles/brutalism-movement/>

<https://www.pentagram.com/work/american-weed-co>

<https://unesco.ru/en/news/gjel37/>

<https://farfor-gzhel.com/en/the-award-at-home-in-the-nomination-design-and-craft/>

Source directory 3

<https://www.demorgan.org.uk/de-morgan-x-loewe-autumn-winter-2019/>

https://www.3m.com/3M/en_US/p/d/v000096543/

<https://www.colorado.edu/anthropology/sites/default/files/attached-files/5leshkovichjonesft.pdf>

<https://www.vam.ac.uk/articles/chinoiserie-an-introduction>

<https://play.studio/work/adobe-max>

<https://about.nike.com/en/magazine/nike-swoosh-logo-history>

<https://thesneeze.com/the-man-behind-the-fedex-logo/>

Source directory 4

<https://www.ibm.com/design/language/ibm-logos/8-bar/>

<https://www.edenbrands.us/services>

<https://www.tiktok.com/@lucyedendesign/video/7665353012268829965>

<https://www.tiktok.com/@lucyedendesign/video/7669805166178209037>

<https://www.edenbrands.us/case-studies/michelle-elman>

<https://www.edenbrands.us/case-studies/splatter>

<https://www.edenbrands.us/case-studies/marlowe-and-sage>

Source directory 5

https://www.linkedin.com/posts/tbwa_our-global-design-studio-dxd-have-taken-us-activity-7492923688888184832-YRdB

<https://tbwa.com/news/>

<https://geist.co/work/anthropic>

<https://www.zachheffner.com/privacy-policy>

<https://investors.oatly.com/static-files/530eaa69-0fb0-40e9-9aac-1147bb6eea14>

<https://palmerlab.berkeley.edu/pdf/Palmer.pdf>

<https://www.cooperhewitt.org/exhibitions/how-posters-work/>

Source directory 6

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/Understanding/contrast-minimum.html>

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/Understanding/animation-from-interactions.html>

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/Understanding/pause-stop-hide.html>

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/Understanding/reflow.html>

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41562-021-01097-6>

<https://web.dev/articles/animations-and-performance>

<https://www.cooperhewitt.org/2014/12/05/making-a-poster-is-a-process/>

Source directory 7

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1-Xuq7o32ZkGV8pxPG61T45pqIr-okEV3/view>

<https://openai.com/policies/how-chatgpt-and-our-foundation-models-are-developed/>

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1CtjBy4KKutNKf97jToAocSG5_M6aGJVq